Specification of the controlled designation of origin "CÔTES DE TOUL"

approved by decree no. 2011-1159 of 22 September 2011, JORF of 24 September 2011; amended by the order of 31 May 2021 published in the JORF of 1 June 2021

CHAPTER I

I. – Name of the designation

Only wines meeting the specific provisions set out below may claim the controlled designation of origin "Côtes de Toul", initially recognised by the decree of 31 March 1998.

II. – Colour and types of product

The controlled designation of origin "Côtes de Toul" is reserved for still white, gris and red wines.

III. – Areas and zones in which the various operations are carried out

1° – Geographical area

The harvesting of the grapes, the vinification and the elaboration of the wines are carried out within the territory of the following communes of the Meurthe-et-Moselle department (list drawn up on the basis of the official geographic code of the year 2025): Blénod-lès-Toul, Bruley, Bulligny, Charmes-la-Côte, Domgermain, Lucey, Mont-le-Vignoble, Pagney-derrière-Barine.

The cartographic documents representing the geographical area may be consulted on the INAO website.

2° – Delimited parcel area

The wines come exclusively from vines situated within the delimited parcel production area as approved by the National Institute of Origin and Quality at the session of the competent national committee of 16 February 1984.

The National Institute of Origin and Quality lodges with the town halls of the communes referred to in 1° the graphic documents establishing the parcel boundaries of the production area thus approved.

3° – Immediate proximity area

The immediate proximity area, defined by derogation for the vinification and the elaboration of the wines, is made up of the territory of the following commune of the Meurthe-et-Moselle department: Toul.

IV. – Grape varieties

1° – Grape varieties

a) – The white wines come from the following varieties: aubin B, auxerrois B.

b) – The red wines come from the single variety pinot noir N.

c) – The gris wines come from the following varieties:

- main varieties: gamay N, pinot noir N;

- accessory varieties: aubin B, auxerrois B, meunier N, pinot gris G.

2° – Proportion rules on the holding

Gris wines:

- The presence of both main varieties in the planting is compulsory.

- The proportion of each of the main varieties is less than or equal to 85 % of the planting.

- The proportion of the pinot noir N variety is greater than or equal to 10 % of the planting.

- The proportion of all the accessory varieties together is less than or equal to 15 % of the planting.

V. – Management of the vineyard

1° – Training methods

a) – Planting density

The vines have a minimum planting density of 4,500 plants per hectare. The spacing between rows may not exceed 2.25 metres and the spacing between plants within the same row may not be less than 0.80 metre nor more than 1.50 metres.

b) – Pruning rules

The vines are pruned either by short spur pruning (Royat cordon) or by single or double Guyot long pruning, with a maximum of 9 free eyes per square metre and:

- a maximum of 15 free eyes per plant for vines with a planting density less than or equal to 6,000 plants per hectare;

- a maximum of 9 free eyes per plant for vines with a planting density greater than 6,000 plants per hectare.

c) – Trellising and foliage height rules

The height of trellised foliage must be at least equal to 0.6 times the spacing between rows. The height of trellised foliage is measured between the attachment wire and the upper trimming limit, set at least 0.20 metre above the upper trellising wire.

d) – Average maximum load per parcel

- The average maximum load per parcel is set at 10,500 kilograms per hectare for the pinot noir N variety.

- The average maximum load per parcel is set at 12,000 kilograms per hectare for the other varieties.

e) – Threshold of missing vines

The percentage of dead or missing vine plants referred to in Article D. 645-4 of the Rural and Maritime Fishing Code is set at 20 %.

f) – Cultivation condition of the vine

The parcels are managed so as to ensure a good overall cultivation condition of the vine, in particular its sanitary condition and the upkeep of its soil.

g) – Establishment and planting of the vineyard

Before each new planting, and for parcels with an area greater than or equal to 5 ares, the operator carries out a physico-chemical analysis of the soil of the parcel in order to have all the elements necessary to understand the viticultural situation and its potential.

2° – Other cultivation practices

a) – Removal of suckers is compulsory. It is carried out by 31 July at the latest.

b) – In order to preserve the characteristics of the soils, which are one of the fundamental elements of the terroir, grass cover of the headlands is compulsory.

3° – Irrigation

Irrigation is prohibited.

VI. – Harvest, transport and ripeness of the grapes

1° – Harvest

The wines come from grapes harvested at good ripeness.

The date of the start of the harvest is set in accordance with the provisions of Article D. 645-6 of the Rural and Maritime Fishing Code.

2° – Ripeness of the grapes

The sugar content of the grapes and the natural alcoholic strengths by volume of the wines meet the following characteristics:

COLOUR OF THE WINES	**MINIMUM SUGAR CONTENT OF THE GRAPES (grams per litre of must)**	**MINIMUM NATURAL ALCOHOLIC STRENGTH BY VOLUME**
Gris wines	153	9.5 %
White wines	161	10 %
Red wines	171	10.5 %

VII. – Yields. – Entry into production

1° – Yield

a) – The yield referred to in Article D. 645-7 of the Rural and Maritime Fishing Code is set, for white and gris wines, at 60 hectolitres per hectare.

b) – The yield referred to in Article D. 645-7 of the Rural and Maritime Fishing Code is set, for red wines, at 45 hectolitres per hectare.

2° – Limit yield

a) – The limit yield referred to in Article D. 645-7 of the Rural and Maritime Fishing Code is set, for white and gris wines, at 72 hectolitres per hectare.

b) – The limit yield referred to in Article D. 645-7 of the Rural and Maritime Fishing Code is set, for red wines, at 54 hectolitres per hectare.

3° – Entry into production of young vines

The benefit of the controlled designation of origin may only be granted to wines coming from:

- parcels of young vines only from the 2nd year following that in the course of which planting was carried out in place before 31 July;

- parcels of young vines only from the 1st year following that in the course of which grafting in place was carried out before 31 July;

- parcels of vines that have been top-grafted, at the earliest in the 1st year following that in the course of which the top-grafting was carried out before 31 July, and once the parcels no longer contain any varieties other than those permitted for the appellation. By derogation, in the year following that in the

course of which the top-grafting was carried out before 31 July, the varieties permitted for the appellation may represent only 80 % of the planting of each parcel concerned.

VIII. – Processing, elaboration, ageing, packaging, storage

1° – General provisions

The wines are vinified in accordance with local, fair and constant usages.

a) – Reception and pressing

Only presses without chains, or from which the chains have been removed, are permitted.

b) – Blending of varieties

Gris wines come from the blending of grapes or wines from at least 2 varieties, which must include the 2 main varieties. The main varieties are in the majority in the blend and represent at least 85 % of the blend. The proportion of all the accessory varieties together is less than or equal to 15 % of the blend.

c) – Malolactic fermentation

Malolactic fermentation is completed for red wines. At the packaging stage, red wines have a malic acid content less than or equal to 0.4 gram per litre.

d) – Analytical standards

- Red wines have, after fermentation, a fermentable sugar content (glucose + fructose) less than or equal to 3 grams per litre.

- White and gris wines have, after fermentation, a fermentable sugar content (glucose + fructose) that does not exceed by more than 2 grams per litre the total acidity expressed in grams of tartaric acid per litre, within a maximum limit of 8 grams per litre.

e) – Oenological practices and physical treatments

- The use of pieces of wood is prohibited.

- Any thermal treatment of the harvest involving a temperature higher than 40 °C is prohibited if it is followed by an immediate separation of the liquid and solid phases.

- After enrichment, the wines do not exceed the following total alcoholic strength by volume:

COLOUR OF THE WINES	TOTAL ALCOHOLIC STRENGTH BY VOLUME
Gris wines	12 %
White wines	12.5 %
Red wines	13 %

f) – Prohibited equipment

- Continuous presses are prohibited.

- Centrifugal pumps for the transfer of the harvest are prohibited.

g) – Vinification vat capacity

Every operator has a vinification vat capacity equivalent to 1.3 times the volume of the previous harvest, for an equal area.

h) – Good overall state of upkeep of the cellar (floor and walls) and of the equipment (hygiene)

The cellar (floors and walls) and the vinification equipment are in a good general state of upkeep.

2° – Provisions by type of product

Gris wines come from the white vinification of the grapes, by draining or immediate pressing.

3° – Provisions relating to packaging

a) – The bottling line is in a good general state of upkeep.

b) – For every packaged lot, the operator keeps available for the approved control body:

- the information appearing in the register of handling operations referred to in Article D. 645-18 of the Rural and Maritime Fishing Code;

- an analysis carried out before packaging.

The analysis reports must be kept for a period of 12 months from the date of packaging.

4° – Provisions relating to storage

The operator provides evidence of a specific place for the storage of packaged products.

5° – Provisions relating to placing on the market for the consumer

The wines are placed on the market for the consumer in accordance with the provisions of Article D. 645-17 of the Rural and Maritime Fishing Code.

IX. – Link with the geographical area

1° – Information on the geographical area

a) – Description of the natural factors contributing to the link

The geographical area extends west of the town of Toul, over a distance of 20 kilometres, along a north–south oriented cuesta resulting from the erosion of sedimentary layers of the Paris Basin. It is bordered by an overlying plateau and overlooks the plain below.

The parcels, precisely delimited for the harvesting of the grapes, thus form part of a landscape characterised by a hillside vineyard underlined by a wooded scarp crest, with orchards at the foot of the slope, opening onto a plain devoted to cereal crops and livestock farming.

The vineyard finds ideal conditions for establishment on the well-exposed slope of the cuesta. This slope is developed on Jurassic (Oxfordian) marls. The marls are covered with limestone scree mixed with clays resulting from their weathering. This slope formation contains more coarse elements at the top of the slope.

The “Côtes de Toul” vineyard is thus located in 8 communes of Meurthe-et-Moselle, one of the four departments of the Lorraine region, a region bordering Germany, Belgium and Luxembourg.

The geographical area enjoys a so-called “temperate continental” climate. However, the influence of oceanic winds is tempered by the topography and the exposure. The resulting mesoclimates are of particular importance for the cultivation of the vine. The slopes, facing east and south and protected from the prevailing winds, overlook the Moselle on its left bank. The altitude lies between 245 metres and 380 metres.

Winters are cold and dry and spring frosts infrequent. Summers are marked by heat with few storms, and autumns are often very sunny.

b) – Description of the human factors contributing to the link

In the 10th century, the "Chapter of Toul" owned very large areas of vines, notably at Bruley and Lucey, where the lieu-dit "Les vignes l'Evêque" ("the Bishop's vines") can still be found. The monasteries, numerous in the region, contributed to the development of the vineyard and its quality.

The Dukes of Lorraine, who shared the wine-growing territory with the Bishops of Toul, worked to maintain the reputation of the wines of the region, which were appreciated at their true worth even in foreign courts. Over the course of their reigns, numerous ordinances established a "Lorraine viticultural code" which remained in force until the eve of the French Revolution. In 1355, an ordinance set the method of cultivation to be used for the vines, and that of 16 April 1666 prohibited intercropping. "Vine cantons" were created in the most favourable areas of the villages enjoying the best exposures, and the right was granted to wine-growing landowners to build presses in their houses for their personal use and that of their less fortunate neighbours.

Thus, until the middle of the 19th century, when it reached its peak, the "Côtes de Toul" vineyard maintained its prestige relative to the lands of the plain. Whereas in the rest of the Lorraine region the urban development of Nancy, the mines and metallurgy of its outskirts, and the foundries of Pont-à-Mousson, Foug and Pompey created a demand for labour that caused the slow decline of the vineyard, the "Côtes de Toul" area maintained its attachment to viticulture.

Thus the producers of the Toulois, wishing to revive the wines that had made the reputation of the "Côtes de Toul" and to perpetuate this heritage, united around a defence syndicate in 1951. The order of 1951 recognised the designation of origin "vin délimité de qualité supérieure" (VDQS) "Côtes de Toul".

In 2009, private cellars represented 45 % of production and had invested heavily in modernising their cellars and in developing reception points for cellar-door sales. Alongside them are a grower-merchant (40 % of production) and a cooperative cellar (15 % of production).

From 1991, a collective investment in research was made into the vinification technique of "gris" wine, with the aim of achieving a qualitative optimum while respecting its originality. This research made it possible in particular to change the varietal composition of the gris wine by reintroducing into the blend a second main variety, pinot noir N, which belongs to the oldest and noblest family of varieties of the vineyard.

These investments and this work led to recognition as the controlled designation of origin "Côtes de Toul" by the decree of 31 March 1998.

2° – Information on the quality and characteristics of the product

Inseparable from the Lorraine identity, the gris wine comes from the white vinification, by draining or immediate pressing, of the fresh harvest. It has a brilliant salmon-pink colour. A dry, light wine with good liveliness and very marked aromatic characteristics, it often shows a nose of fresh fruit and a palate that is moreish and fresh.

The white wines, from the local auxerrois B variety, have a nose that can evolve towards citrus notes and a rather floral palate, ample on the attack, structured and long.

The red wines, from the single variety pinot noir N, are finely tannic, full-bodied, all roundness and finesse.

3° – Causal interactions

Already sung in Antiquity by the Roman poet AUSONIUS, the "Côtes de Toul" vineyard still existed in the Carolingian era and developed under the impetus of the Dukes of Lorraine and the Bishops of Toul. The controlled designation of origin "Côtes de Toul" has thus been built on the basis of an important historical heritage, developed and enriched by the collective will of a core group of stakeholders to perpetuate this viticultural activity.

The east- and south-facing exposures and the topography guarantee sunshine and protection from the prevailing winds, essential for a northern vineyard. The clay-limestone and stony soils provide both the necessary water reserve and good drainage, the latter being favoured by the natural slope of the hillsides.

This soil and climate context gives the gris and white wines their freshness and their floral or fruity notes, and ensures good phenolic ripeness of the grapes, which is reflected in particular in the tannic structure of the red wines. These characteristics are protected by the use of equipment that preserves the potential of the harvest (no continuous or chain presses, no centrifugal pumps).

This soil and climate context also requires optimal management of the plant and its production potential, in particular through high trellising of the foliage and compulsory removal of suckers, in order to guarantee satisfactory ripeness and an optimal sanitary condition of the vines and berries.

The “Côtes de Toul” vineyard built its reputation on gris wine. At the end of the 19th century, the wines produced in the Toul region corresponded to what was called “vin gris de Lorraine” and were generally sold under the name “Vin gris du Toulois” or “Vin gris des Côtes de Toul”. These wines were highly appreciated by a loyal clientele of connoisseurs and restaurateurs of the eastern region and of the capital. The gris wine also owes its reputation to the presence in the region of numerous barracks, housing soldiers from all the regions of France.

The development of know-how within this community of producers around gris wine was naturally applied to the production of white and red wines, which enjoy a growing renown. Plantings of the pinot noir N variety for the gris wine blend have made possible a return to the usages of red wine production. The technical itinerary imposed for obtaining gris wines is of course applied to the white varieties, which gives the white wines their finesse and structure, already recognised by Jules Guyot (1822), who particularly appreciated those of the commune of Bruley.

In 2010, the quality and specificity of the “Côtes de Toul” wines were recognised and acclaimed by the leading wine guides (Guide Hachette) and national competitions (Concours Général Agricole de Paris). Likewise, the location of the geographical area, within a region bordering three European countries linked to one another by the Moselle valley, plays an important role in the development of this renown.

X. – Transitional measures

a) – The provisions relating to planting density, spacing between rows and spacing between plants within the same row do not apply to vine parcels in place before 31 March 1998. These parcels continue to benefit, for their harvest, from the right to the controlled designation of origin until they are grubbed up and at the latest until the 2023 harvest inclusive.

b) – Vine parcels trained according to the so-called “lyre” training method continue to benefit, for their harvest, from the right to the controlled designation of origin until they are grubbed up and at the latest until the 2023 harvest inclusive.

XI. – Rules of presentation and labelling

1° – General provisions

Wines for which, under the terms of the present specification, the controlled designation of origin “Côtes de Toul” is claimed and which are presented under the said appellation may not be declared after the harvest, offered to the public, dispatched, put up for sale or sold unless, in the harvest declaration, in advertisements, on leaflets, labels, invoices and any containers whatsoever, the aforesaid controlled designation of origin is entered.

2° – Particular provisions

All optional indications are entered on the labels in characters whose dimensions, both in height and in width, are not greater than double those of the characters composing the name of the controlled designation of origin.

CHAPTER II

I. – Declaration obligations

1. Prior declaration of parcel assignment

Every operator declares to the defence and management body the list of parcels assigned to the production of the controlled designation of origin before 15 May preceding the harvest.

This declaration is renewable by tacit renewal, unless changes are notified by the operator before 15 May preceding the harvest.

This declaration specifies:

- the identity of the operator;

- the EVV or SIRET number;

- the cooperative cellar(s) to which the operator may deliver;

- for each parcel: the cadastral reference, the area, the year of planting and the grape variety.

The operator may declare to the defence and management body that they renounce producing the controlled designation of origin at the latest on 15 May preceding the harvest.

2. Claim declaration

The claim declaration is lodged with the defence and management body at least fifteen days before the first exit of products from the vinification cellar and at the latest sixty days after the date of placing on the market for the consumer.

It indicates:

- the designation claimed;

- the volume of the wine;

- the EVV or SIRET number;

- the name and address of the applicant;

- the place of storage of the wine.

It is accompanied by:

- a copy of the harvest declaration and, as the case may be, a copy of the production declaration or an extract of the stock accounts for buyers of grapes and musts;

- the general plan of the storage places.

3. Prior transaction declaration

Every operator wishing to sell a wine of the controlled designation of origin in bulk declares the transaction for the lot concerned to the approved control body and to the defence and management body between the day the transaction is contracted and at the latest fifteen days before collection.

The lot is defined as a homogeneous whole coming from one or more containers.

4. Prior packaging declaration

Every operator wishing to package a wine benefiting from the controlled designation of origin must send an extract of their packaging register to the approved control body each quarter and at the latest on the 10th of the first month of the following quarter.

5. Declaration relating to the dispatch outside the national territory of a non-packaged wine

Every operator wishing to dispatch outside the national territory a non-packaged wine benefiting from the controlled designation of origin must declare it to the approved control body at least fifteen days before the dispatch.

6. Downgrading declaration

Every operator carrying out a downgrading of wines benefiting from the controlled designation of origin must declare it to the defence and management body and to the approved control body within a maximum period of fifteen working days after this downgrading.

CHAPTER III

I. – Main points to be checked and evaluation methods

MAIN POINTS TO BE CHECKED	EVALUATION METHODS
A – STRUCTURAL RULES	
A1 – Belonging of the planted parcels to the delimited area.	Documentary and visual.
A2 – Claimable production potential (planting density and trellising, entry of the vines into production).	Documentary, visual and measurements.
A3 – Processing, ageing, packaging and storage facilities.	
Prohibited equipment	Visual.
Place of vinification.	Documentary and visual.
Traceability of packaging.	Documentary.
Justified storage place for packaged products.	Documentary and visual.
B – RULES LINKED TO THE PRODUCTION CYCLE	
B1 – Management of the vineyard.	
Pruning.	Measurements.
Average maximum load per parcel.	Measurements.
Other cultivation practices	Measurements and visual.
B2 – Harvest, transport and ripeness of the grapes.	
Ripeness of the grapes.	Documentary.
Monitoring of the harvest date.	Documentary.
B3 – Processing, elaboration, ageing, packaging, storage.	
Pressing.	Documentary and visual.
Blending of varieties.	Documentary and visual.
Oenological practices or treatments (enrichment, prohibited practices…)	Documentary and visual.
Vinification vat capacity.	Documentary and visual.

MAIN POINTS TO BE CHECKED	EVALUATION METHODS
B4 – Harvest declaration and claim declaration.	
Missing vines.	Documentary and visual.
Authorised yield.	Documentary.
Claim declaration.	Documentary and visual.
C – CHECKS ON THE PRODUCTS	
Non-packaged wines, at transaction	Analytical and organoleptic examination.
Packaged wines	Analytical and organoleptic examination.
Non-packaged wines intended for dispatch outside the national territory.	Analytical and organoleptic examination.
D – PRESENTATION OF THE PRODUCTS	
Labelling.	Documentary and visual.

II. – References concerning the control structure

Institut National de l'Origine et de la Qualité (INAO)

TSA 30003, 93555 Montreuil Cedex, telephone: (33) (0)1-73-30-38-00, email: contact@inao.gouv.fr

Compliance with the present specification is checked on the basis of an approved control plan, by a third-party body offering guarantees of competence, impartiality and independence that has received delegation from the INAO.